

Ari Logan's Writing Process

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I've found out a lot about how I write, and I now have the ability to put it into words. I'm going to guide you through what I've discovered. I'll start with what motivates me, why I procrastinate, and what those things mean to me. Then I'll move into what I write when I'm just getting started with a project. The next step is to take a detour and discuss what I obsess over when I write. That leads to my distractions and how I've chosen to embrace them. And then I'll finally go over how I view writing the rest of an essay. Finally, I'll finish off with anything I might've missed but still want to cover because it's important to my writing and thought processes.

Procrastination and motivation

When I write, the first step is always to procrastinate. Wait until the last day, and don't start working until the sun starts to set. I both know and don't know why I do this. I know that I don't enjoy reading dry academic texts, so what really motivates me to start writing is to really feel that stress of an upcoming deadline. But I don't know, because I always end up enjoying what I write, and when I do start working early, it's the best feeling in the world to be done with all my responsibilities and still have most of the day left. In my writing log, you can see a consistent pattern of starting after 8 PM. (e.g., "Reading Discussion: Linguistic Diversity & Code-Meshing (Writer's Choice) - 5/7/26 at 10 PM", "Psyc 100: Annotated bibliography – 5/14/26 at 9 PM", "Psyc 100: module 6 discussion – 5/16/26 at 8:45 PM"). It leads to me being under a steady level of stress when I'm writing, which causes me to hesitate to write the next time I need to. But connecting back to where I said that stress is my main motivator when writing, I noticed the one time in my writing log where I wrote before noon. It was an interview thank-you email for an internship, which doesn't have a set deadline, just a general

recommended range. I know that hard deadlines are the bane of my existence because I wait till the very last minute. I wish I had more examples that I could draw from, but if they aren't there, that motivating stress pops up right away to make to start working as soon as I can.

Getting started

Now, once I finally get started, there's a few other obstacles. It used to be that I caused myself a lot of stress when I wrote because I didn't like my thought process, and I'd be constantly starting over without having written anything down. Usually what it means is having a thought, then trying to elaborate on it and not being satisfied with what I can think of. I note this phenomenon in my self-portrait. "And then once I've started, it's hard to think of ideas to add to, or to expand upon because every idea is unprofessional or somehow unintelligent." It's this unfortunate habit of treating my first draft as a final draft and worrying that people are reading what I'm writing, and they're judging me very hard. But that's changed. My writing process is to just start transcribing what I'm thinking. From my writing log on my self-portrait: "Every thought is a valid thought; I can get rid of what I don't like later." It's very liberating, as it takes less time (necessary when I only have 3 hours to complete an assignment), and it allows me to worry about being critical for the end. As noted by Anne Lamott when discussing first drafts:

No one is going to see it. If the kid wants to get into really sentimental, weepy, emotional territory, you let him. Just get it all down on paper because there may be something great in those six crazy pages that you would never have gotten to by more rational, grown-up means (2005, para. 4).

When I treat my ideas with some respect, they can build each other, and I start creating structure for my text early, instead of scrambling to manufacture one at the end.

Obsession with format and rubric

Once I've got my writing going, there's something I notice I do a lot. Now it's not perfecting my thoughts before I write them down, it's obsessing over format. This is connected to what I write about related to information technology: "I should use large headers and properly use tables of contents, appropriately use color coding, font choice, and text size for those with visual impairments" (Self-Portrait). I'm referring to the word processing tools I use to make my work accessible and readable to a wide audience. I'm obsessed with these things. Unfortunately for me, most of my writing recently has had to be done in APA format, which has a lot of quirks and nuances to it. I take so much time beforehand worrying if I'm using quotes correctly, if the periods and commas are in the right places, that there is never a smooth flow to my writing. There's always a little bit of time every few minutes making dead sure I formatted that sentence correctly. As I wrote my Rhetorical situation assignment, I "Was paying extra close attention to my formatting, and conformity to APA. Keep trying to add thoughts to get the page requirement" (Writing log). That quote also brings up another point, which is that I have a love-hate relationship with rubrics. I use them as a crutch as to whether my writing is adequate, instead of just judging my writing on its own. There's so much time spent looking over my work, seeing what else I can squeeze out to meet an arbitrary length requirement.

Distractions

When I'm writing, I notice I tend to get bored if I stick to something too long. So, I need to take some breaks and grab a snack. Maybe I will give into my distractions a little bit. I've found these are all good things for my writing. Once I get up to grab a snack, I have a little bit of time to reflect on how much I've got done and refuel my energy. If I get bored of my work, spending a couple minutes watching a YouTube video or continuing the show I'm watching is hugely beneficial. Boredom isn't helpful when trying to think of ideas to add to an essay. I can

work through my distractions and still get my work done. I noted in my writing log that when I was at the mall doing the module 6 discussion for my psychology class, “The group of people I was with were having a conversation, and sometimes I'd have something to say.” Even though I got distracted by the commotion around me, I'd engage in the distraction for a moment, which would allow me to refresh my creative juices, get back some energy, and then I could go back to work. I don't think of distractions as something to eliminate; I embrace them and view them as an opportunity to reset. If I'm ever in a rut and am struggling to think of ideas, taking a short little break is the best thing to do.

Arguing my points

Now I can talk about how I write the “meat” of my work. I like to think about anything I write as if it's part of an argument. If I'm trying to convince someone of what I want from them, I need to properly give them background information for my thoughts, or else a lot of the message is lost. Here's what I say on this topic in my self-portrait: “If my reasoning or arguments aren't all properly portrayed, my position is much easier to take down in rebuttal.” Just like I would in an argument, I'm going to make sure my context is accounted for when writing. For example, if I'm trying to inform someone about rhetoric, I'm going to be extra vigilant about how I introduce the different parts of the rhetorical situation; how do I define each aspect of the rhetorical situation? This way, the reader has the necessary context to understand how I apply different parts of the rhetorical situation to certain concepts. Another thing I make sure I have when making a point is a level of critical reflection. Now that I've defined my different concepts, how are they applied in different situations, what are some examples? How would someone who isn't me view what I said? Now that's not always easy, especially if you're as critical of your ideas as I am. But as I said in my writing log about when I was responding to module 6

discussion posts: “It may seem hard to be a critical thinker, but it’s not too hard after just giving it some thought and being a bit more open on what I feel I can write about.” Easily the biggest thing I learned when discovering how I write, is to not be so worried about how you’ll come across in your first draft, or even your final draft. Ideas can be revised later, and it’s way harder to come up with new ones when you realize your essay is missing important information and context.

What else I've learned

I have just one big idea I want to cover, the idea that scholarly articles do not need to conform to a singular method of communication. An article written in “street talk” is just as valuable as anything written using dry “Standard Written English.” What gave me this realization was “Should Writers Use They Own English?” by Vershawn Ashanti Young, and more specifically where he says, “He also blend in oral speech patterns (with the phonological representation of words like ‘fo sho’ and ‘befo’). And his book is published by an academic press and marketed to teachers of English” (2010) when referring to the language used by a professor. Both Young and the professors’ works were published in legitimate academic journals, even though they both use vernacular. Maybe I don’t have to be so worried about when I use contractions because the Microsoft Word editor told me so.